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Travel Radio Australia, Travel Radio World and I'm with a special guest here at the World Travel Market in London. It's Michelle Pianowski and she's a solo traveler and she actually advises people on solo travel and we just call her PJ. PJ, welcome to the program.

Thank you so much for having me, excited to be talking. Now PJ, tell us about what you do. Solo travel these days is a huge business.

People are going around by themselves and discovering the world. Exactly, it's becoming enormous. I run an Instagram page showing people exactly how they can start solo traveling and everything that they need to know as well as how they can save up for their trips and get started with that.

It's absolutely my passion. I've been solo traveling for almost a decade at this point and my first trip was an accident. I didn't know I was going to be going somewhere on my own but I ended up traveling across Canada by train solo and since then I've been completely hooked and I've been to 75 countries in my life.

Wow, 75 countries, that's incredible. You're such a young person, you're in your 20s and that's a really huge achievement. Thank you.

Now tell us about some of your favorite places. You're based in Switzerland and you were telling me a bit about your background. Your background itself was quite amazing and interesting.

Yes, that's true. I was raised by two parents who immigrated from Poland to Canada, grew up in Calgary, Alberta and the last five years I've spent living in Switzerland and most recently I've started to travel full-time. So that's a new adventure for me as well.

Yes, tell us about where you're based in Switzerland. You fan out all across Europe from there. I was based in a town called Zug right in between Zurich and Lucerne.

That's a beautiful place. It's a very Swiss place I must say. I have a friend who has a big house there and tell us about some of your favorite places in Europe to start off with.

In Europe, I mean there's so many beautiful places and it will totally depend on what people want from their trips but I mean Italy is a classic and even though it is a very popular destination, it still is one of my favorite countries. Despite visiting 20 times or so, I love going back every time. So I still say Italy is one of the best but on the more underrated side, which is what I like to talk about often, I love Albania.

Albania has something for everybody. It has amazing mountains, great hiking, it has the sea, it has really interesting unique cities. I love taking like two or three week road trips to Albania if somebody has the time to do that.

So that's and of course Poland. I have to mention Poland as somebody who's Polish. It's a country that has so much to offer as well and they are some of the best cooks in all of Europe.

Now Gdansk is one of my favorite places and that is a really great destination because it's a bit like Amsterdam. The architecture is fantastic. Yes, it is.

The Baltic area in general offers so much beauty in their cities. The tall buildings, very colorful and really lovely people all around the Baltics. Now we must say about the new EES system because the entry exit system for Europe because that that has just come into play in October 2025 and that is a system people have to be mindful about that if they're coming for an extended period, a three-month trip.

Yes, definitely. I haven't had to use it yet so I haven't traveled out of the continent and back yet but I hear that it's especially important to come to the airport quite early these days in most of the European airports because that is causing some trouble and some delays so definitely be mindful of that if you'll be traveling anytime soon. How can people find you on Instagram to find out more about what you do? I'm speaking with Michelle PJ.

She's a solo travel expert. She's been to how many countries again? 75. Well tell us firstly how people can find you on Instagram then we'll go through a couple of more of the countries that you love.

That sounds good. You can find me at hey.pj like hey what's up. Scandinavia.

I lived there in Sweden for eight years and I suppose you have a few of your favorite spots there too. Yes, but to be honest I haven't explored Scandinavia as much as I would have liked to. I've been to all the capital cities and a little bit more in some smaller areas but that's somewhere I actually still have to go back to.

I have a goal to visit more of North Norway in the coming months. Hope to. You know the Lapland, that area and I suppose did you see the Northern Lights yet? Yes, actually where I grew up in Canada we get Northern Lights so I grew up with them.

Very lucky to have that. Yes and Calgary is a beautiful place too. I was there for the Winter Olympics in 88 and it's a fantastic place and you weren't even born back then probably but no but it is a fantastic warm welcoming environment in Alberta.

Yes, Calgary is a great city and it's actually in my opinion gotten quite a bit better over the last ten years or so. Lots of change in the food scene, lots in the culture so there's a lot to do there and of course you're right beside Banff National Park so amazing mountains, the Rockies right in the area. Your absolute favourite destinations? Give me three and why.

I think my very favourite is still Vietnam. I absolutely fell in love with this country when I first

visited it two or three years ago. It has everything.

It has incredible food, it has incredible people and it has a variety of landscapes. Everything you'd want to see you can find in Vietnam and it is just so beautiful so I love Vietnam. Very good energy there.

The next favourite would probably be Colombia. That's one I visited more recently at the beginning of this year. I was there for a month and I completely fell in love with it.

Everything from Cartagena to Medellin to Bucaramanga is gorgeous and again very good energy there, really lovely people though I have to say if you don't speak any Spanish it is a little tougher to get around so I recommend brushing up on your Spanish if you're gonna be traveling there sometime soon. And a third country, oh so tough. I would probably say off the top of my head Malaysia was one that hit pretty high on my list.

It surprised me and I think that's why I ended up liking it so much. I didn't have very high expectations but again was very surprised by the food scene especially. I had no idea how amazing Malaysian food is and how much variety there is in their food so that was a really pleasant surprise but also just how many different places there are, how many cute cultural cities there are to visit there, that you have the tea fields and beautiful greenery, you have nice mountains as well so something for everybody in in Malaysia too.

Well it's such a wonderful life you're leading here and I suppose what's your future goal to hit as many countries as you can, maybe all of them? Oh I hope that one day I get to go to pretty much every country. It's not a goal that I track actively even when I track how many countries I've been to, I don't do it in the sense that I'm trying to get to as many as soon as possible. I have hopefully a good maybe 60-70 more years to live so I've got time to see them all I'd say.

I'll do it nice and slow and go back to the places that get me excited when I find them but I find it quite interesting to try and push myself to new destinations so that's why I keep some track but a more immediate goal for me will be to do an Antarctica trip and I hope to do that at the start of next year. Well that's down by Australia so you can actually pop, have you been to Australia's yet? Yes just in Melbourne and Sydney though so I hear I have to go back and explore more of the outback. Oh well you definitely have to come to Queensland and the Great Barrier Reef I suppose that's on your bucket list too.

100%. Yes come and see us there on the reef and you'll absolutely love it and once more it's Michelle Pianowski and they call her PJ she's based in Switzerland she travels all over the world as a solo traveler and if you want to solo travel check out her Instagram just to remind us again how to find that. It's hey.pj. Hey.pj as in H E Y okay that's perfect.

Thank you PJ for being on the program and good luck with all your travels and and it's great to have you along. Thank you so much for having me.

